Ankle strengthening exercises PDF

An evidence-based ankle strengthening and mobility programme from Living With Arthritis.

Use a comfortable range, build up gradually and follow your clinician's advice. Stop if an exercise causes new or worsening pain.

1. Double-leg heel raise - straight legs

1. Stand with feet hip-width apart and hold a sturdy chair.
2. Keep your knees straight and lift both heels.
3. Lower slowly over 4-5 seconds.

Up to 15 repetitions | 2-3 sets | Rest 1 minute

2. Supported squat

1. Stand with feet shoulder-width apart and hold a sturdy chair.
2. Sit your hips back, bending your knees only as far as comfortable.
3. Keep both heels down, then return to standing.

Up to 15 repetitions | 2-3 sets | Rest 1 minute

3. Double-leg heel raise - knees bent

1. Stand with feet hip-width apart and knees slightly bent.
2. Keep the small knee bend while lifting both heels.
3. Lower slowly and stop if you cannot control the movement.

Up to 10 repetitions | 2-3 sets | Rest 1 minute

4. Towel stretch - calf

1. Sit upright with one leg straight in front of you.
2. Loop a towel around the ball of your foot and gently draw your foot towards you.
3. Keep your knee straight and do not force the stretch.

Hold up to 30 seconds | Repeat 3 times

5. Ankle movement - point and flex

1. Support your lower leg and keep your knee still.
2. Slowly point your foot away, then draw your toes towards your shin.
3. Move through a comfortable, pain-free range.

Hold up to 30 seconds | Repeat 3 times

Exercise safely

For standing exercises, use a sturdy non-wheeled chair on a non-slip floor. Check with a physiotherapist if you are unsure, have a recent injury or have had surgery. This resource provides general information and is not individual medical advice.

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